World History 3500 BCE to 1300 CE

HIST219P

M-W-F, 9–9:50 AM
Key 0103



Figure 1: Scholars at a world history conference in 9th century Baghdad

Instructor

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Office hours: M-W 10-11 and by appointment
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Course description

What is the story of human societies, and how did we come to be the dominant species on the globe? What have been the processes through which we have built complex relationships, societies, and states? This course is designed as an introduction both to the historical discipline and as an overview to human history until the beginning of what many scholars deem "the modern period." We begin with summary of human history until the time of the first states and written cultures, after which we proceed more slowly on a both a thematic and a geographic basis, roughly following but not fully wedded to the historical chronology of events and cultures. Questions we will ask include: What is the purpose of studying world history? When do we begin to see a fully connected world? Has Eurasia always been at the core of human history since the development of states, and what is at stake when we use the concept of "civilization" in the historical sense?

This is mainly a lecture course, although discussion will be incorporated into each session. Attending lecture is crucial, as there will be several map quizzes. The bulk of the readings are texts or images from the periods in question (what historians call primary sources). However, often an additional textbook reading will be provided from Robert W. Strayer, *Ways of the World* (3rd edition, 2015). Although not strictly required, this reading provides highly recommended background material, and it will also assist you in the several map quizzes that you will take over the course of the class. One of the themes of this class is the global dimensions of Arabic historical and geographic writing, which we use in readings for 4 separate weeks on the Middle East, China, and Africa (in translation, of course). All readings for the course will be made available on Canvas (**elms)**, there are no required texts for purchase.

Analytical questions

Part 1 (early states, 3500-500 BCE) What is a state? Where and why did the earliest states arise? What were their most notable innovations? What kinds of sources do historians have access to for this period?

Part 2 (the classical era, 500 BCE – 500 CE) What major political and economic centers emerged during this period? What is religion, and what was its relationship to state structures? What other forms of hierarchy emerged? How did early American states differ from Eurasian states? How did differing geographic conditions impact their ways of life? Is Eurasia a useful term for the history of this period?

Part 3 (a connected globe, 500 CE – 1300 CE) In what ways did Afro-Eurasia become more connected during this period? Which parts of the globe became organized as states for the first time, and which parts were colonized or explored for the first time? What is the relationship between Europe and Christendom? How did empires during this period differ from those of the "classical era"?

Assignments and grade basis

Participation 10% - In class discussion, office hours (students must come in at least once in preparation for the final paper).

Map quizzes 20%

Mid-term exam 30%

Final paper 40% - Choose two primary sources from the same period and explain why you do so (they may tell a story together, contradict one another, for instance). Examine them for reliability and bias, then draw conclusions about the benefits and drawbacks of different kinds of sources in the study of history. If the sources are from different regions, explain why they still merit comparison. The paper should be between 1,250 and 1,500 words (5-6 pages, double-spaced). You are required to meet with the instructor during office hours during the planning stages of the paper.

Policies, guidelines, resources

It is the student's responsibility to inform the instructor of any intended absences for religious observances in advance, especially if they overlap with exam dates.

If you expect to miss a quiz or exam, you must contact the instructor in advance in order to schedule a make-up.

Accessibility and Disability Service: (https://www.counseling.umd.edu/ads). Students with a documented disability should inform the instructors within the add-drop period if academic accommodations will be needed. **You are expected to meet with your instructor in person** to provide them with a copy of the *Accommodations Letter* and to obtain your instructor's signature on the *Acknowledgement of Student Request* form. You and your instructor will plan together how accommodations will be implemented throughout the semester. To obtain the required Accommodation Letter, please contact Accessibility and Disability Service (ADS) at 301-314-7682 or adsfrontdesk@umd.edu.

Course schedule:

Part one: The beginning and early states, 3500-500 BCE

Week 1 Introduction to humans	**Mon** Introduction: the goals of world history and the trajectory of the field **Wed** The human race to 12,000 years ago – evolution and migrations **Fri** Agricultural revolution and the growth of cities **Readings** Strayer and Nelson, *Ways of the World: A Brief Global History with Sources*, 3rd edition (2015), 12-46; Wigen and Lewis, *The Myth of Continents* (1997), 1-3; 33-45; 13-14.
Week 2 The first states	**M** City states: Mesopotamia, Indus Valley **W** Large unified states: Egypt's first kingdoms **F** The Near Eastern state system in the 2nd millennium; *discussion with primary sources: Mesopotamian kingship* **Background readings** Strayer, 59-96 **Primary source** *Epic of Gilgamesh*, Code of Hammurabi (excerpts)
Week 3 Themes in early political systems	**M** Shang and Zhou China; Eurasian geography **W** Early American cultures; Writing systems and the power of the written word **F** Map quiz (Eurasian geography); *discussion with primary sources* **Background readings** Strayer, 59-96 (same as week 2) **Primary source** The Papyrus Lansing, the Satire of the Trades
Week 4 Fragmentation & war	**M** Axial Age intro; South Asia, Vedic Age, and Buddha. **W** Warring states period in China; the Assyrian Empire and it's collapse

F Primary source discussion

Background readings Strayer, 105-135

Primary source The 4 Noble Truths and the Way; Confucius

Part II: The Classical Era, 500 BCE – 500 CE

Week 5
New peoples, new encounters

M Global Migrations (Bantu, Celtic, Austronesian); The Greek city-states

W The Persians Empire; Zoroastrianism & Judaism; Alexander

F Primary source discussion

Background readings Strayer, 105-135 (same as week 4)

Primary source Herodotus, *The Histories*

Week 6
Centralized states: Imperial Rome & Han China

M Expansion and incorporation, political history (military primary sources)

W Elite culture, order, and hierarchy; Christianity and Daoism

F Primary source discussion: critiquing imperial rule

Background readings Strayer, 147-181

Primary sources Tacitus, *Annals*, on Emperor Nero; Sima Qian, *The Records of the Grand Historian* on first Han ruler Kao-tsu.

Week 7
Religion and hierarchy in Eurasia

M The Mauryan and Kushan Empires

W Mid-term review

F Mid-term exam

Readings Strayer, 191-217

Primary source Ashoka pillar inscriptions

Week 8
Growth and connectivity in and around Africa

M Trade networks in Afro-Eurasia: silk roads & nomads, the Gupta Empire

W Classical civilizations: Nubia and Axum, and Indian Ocean trade; the spread of Christianity (Map quiz, classical empires)

F Niger River Valley and the Sahara trade; The spread of Bantu culture

Background readings Strayer, 230-241; Peter B. Golden, "The rise of nomadism and oasis city-states," *Central Asia in world history*, 9-21

Primary sources *The Periplus of the Erythraen Sea* (1st century CE); *The Christian Topography* (6th century CE)

Week 9
Isolated worlds: The Americas

M Mesoamerica – Olmec and Maya cultures

W The Andes culture – Moche, Wari, and Tiwanaku

F North American settlements

Background readings Strayer, 241-263

Primary sources *The Popol Vuh* (Mayan creation myth); Plan and pictures of Tenotihuacan; Moche grave findings (Strayer, 251)

Part 3: 500 CE – 1500 CE, a connected globe

Week 10
Monotheism grows: Christianity and Islam

M The spread of Christianity through Asia, Africa, and Europe

W The growth of early Islam out of the Roman-Sassanid context

F The Abbasid Empire, Baghdad, and reformulation of pre-existing imperial intellectual traditions

Background readings Strayer, 371-396; Fred Donner, *Muhammad and the Believers* (2010)

Primary sources Inscription on Dome of the Rock; al-Kindi, *the Apology*

Week 11
Recovery and growth in Europe

M Europe after Rome: fragmentation, Slavic migrations

W Renewed centralized power in the Holy Roman Empire

F Map quiz (Spread of Islam); The height of Byzantine power: 9th-11th centuries

Readings Strayer, 409-434, Chris Wickham

Primary sources Gregory of Tours, *History of the Franks*; *The Song of Roland* passages

Week 12
Movements and encounters across steppe and ocean

M Pushing the boundaries of the sea: Vikings and Polynesians

W The nomadic challenge to China and the Islamic world

F The Crusader period and Europe's first outward expansion

Readings Strayer, 258-262, 434-446

Primary sources Usama ibn al-Munqidh, *The book of contemplation: Islam and the Crusades*

Week 13
East Asia

M Tang China

W Dealing with Chinese power: Japan, Korea, Vietnam

F East Asia and the Eurasian Economy

Background readings *Strayer*, 323-353

Primary sources Account of Suleiman al-Tajir's travels in China and Tang business practices

Week 14
Trade networks and global connectivity

M Silk road & Indian Ocean trade networks; trade, culture, and disease

W Trade hubs in Southeast Asia and East Africa

F Map quiz (Late medievalEurasian trade); West Africa's first large kingdoms

	Background readings *Strayer*, 301-305; **Primary sources** Ibn Battuta, *al-Rihla*, on Mogadishu and Mali Empire
Week 15 Crisis and change	**M** The Mongol invasions in Eurasia; Collapse of Civilizations in the Americas and the Columbian exchange.